✦ STEP 6

Evidence Cards

One card for each side, ready to read, plus how to build and cut your own cards honestly.

✧ What's in a card

1. **Tag:** one short line, in **your own words**, saying what the card proves.
2. **Cite:** author, their qualifications, publication, date and link.
3. **Evidence:** the exact words from the source. **Highlighted** parts are what you read out loud.

✧ Affirmative card

AFF · Location / China — **Meservey, 2021**

China's control of Djibouti puts U.S. forces at risk, so recognizing Somaliland gives the U.S. a backup partner in the region.

Meservey, 2021. Joshua Meservey, Senior Policy Analyst for Africa and the Middle East CHECK BYLINE, Heritage Foundation, "The U.S. Should Recognize Somaliland," October 19, 2021. heritage.org

Beijing recently built in Djibouti its only overseas military base, a hardened encampment whose quay can support a Chinese aircraft carrier. Beijing's lavish financing of Djiboutian infrastructure has made Djibouti at high risk of debt distress, and **China is by far Djibouti's largest trading partner**. The Chinese government financed—and Chinese companies built—sensitive Djiboutian buildings such as the foreign ministry headquarters and the People's Palace. State-controlled China Merchants Port Holdings manages three of Djibouti Port's terminals. It and four other Chinese companies are involved in various ways in the ownership, construction, and operation of what will be Africa's largest free trade zone, the Djibouti International Free Trade Zone. **Beijing's unparalleled influence in the country has already impeded American operations**—and **positions China to shut down U.S. activity** in the case of a confrontation between the two countries.

EXTRA FACT YOU CAN SAY OUT LOUD

From the same report's footnote 20: in **2018**, lasers fired from the Chinese base targeted U.S. military aircraft and **injured two U.S. airmen**. Say: "The report also notes that..."

⚠ **BE READY FOR**

- **"It's from 2021!"** → "The key facts haven't changed. China's base is still in Djibouti, right next to ours. Old evidence is fine when the facts are still true." VERIFY (find a 2025–26 article showing the base is still active)
- **"Heritage is biased."** → "It's written by an Africa expert, and the report even lists the downsides of recognition."
- **"It never mentions Somaliland."** → This paragraph proves Djibouti is risky. You explain the link: so the U.S. needs a backup partner nearby, Somaliland and its port of Berbera.

✧ Negative card

🟥 **NEG · Al-Shabaab risk** **CRS, 2026**

The U.S. and Somalia fight al-Shabaab together, so recognizing Somaliland risks that partnership.

CRS, 2026. Congressional Research Service (Congress's nonpartisan research office), "Somalia," In Focus IF10155, updated July 21, 2026. everycrsreport.com

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U.S. airstrikes in Somalia have increased sharply under the Trump Administration, with **over 130 strikes in 2025 and nearly 70 in the first half of 2026**. AFRICOM continues to report that the strikes are **done in coordination with Somalia's government**. Successive U.S. Administrations have termed **Al Shabaab an "associated force" of Al Qaeda** in the context of the 2001 Authorization for Use of Military Force (AUMF; P.L. 107-40) and have interpreted the AUMF as authorizing operations against the Islamic State.

💡 **WHAT THE LAST SENTENCE MEANS**

After 9/11, Congress passed a law (the AUMF) allowing the U.S. to fight al-Qaeda and groups connected to it. The U.S. says al-Shabaab counts. That's **why** the U.S. is bombing in Somalia, and it connects the strikes to al-Shabaab.

⚠ **WHY THE CARD STOPS THERE**

The next sentence says U.S. strikes killed al-Shabaab leaders, "**but** UN terrorism experts suggest" that may not weaken the group. Reading only the first half would change the author's meaning. That's called **clipping**, and it's cheating. Stopping before the whole sentence is fine.

Alternate Neg card (same report)

For the **"benefits without recognition"** contention:

🟥 **NEG · Benefits without recognition** **CRS, 2026**

The U.S. already works with Somaliland without recognizing it.

CRS, 2026. Same citation as above.

U.S. officials have made several visits to Somaliland and discussed opportunities for further engagement, but the State Department reported to Congress in 2026 that the United States continues to recognize "the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Federal Republic of Somalia, which includes the region of Somaliland."

✧ How to tell if a source is credible

1. **Who wrote it?** An expert, reporter or government official is good. An anonymous blog is not.
2. **Who published it?** A well-known news outlet, think tank or government site is good.
3. **Is it selling something?** Groups lobbying for Somaliland or for Somalia are biased. Judges notice.

Type	Good examples
News	AP, Reuters, BBC, VOA, Foreign Policy
Think tanks	Heritage Foundation, Council on Foreign Relations, Crisis Group, Brookings, FPRI
Government	Congressional Research Service, state.gov, congress.gov, africom.mil

Don't use as a card: Wikipedia (fine for background), personal blogs, social media, or sites run by Somaliland or Somalia advocates.

Notes on specific sources

- **Middle East Eye:** a real London-based news site, but with a point of view (its headline called the 2026 report a "blow to Somaliland and Israel"). Quote facts, not opinions, and credit the government report it describes.
- **AFRICOM:** the U.S. military reporting on itself. Reliable for when and where strikes happened, but it may make itself look good. Human rights groups have found civilian deaths it didn't report at first. VERIFY
- **CRS:** the gold standard. Neutral, written for Congress, and no judge will question it.

✧ How to cut a card

- ◇ Copy the paragraph exactly. Don't change any words.
- ◇ Remove footnotes and footnote numbers (they're citations, not the argument).
- ◇ Make sure the card actually **proves the tag**. If it doesn't name what you're arguing about (for example, al-Shabaab), add the sentence that does.
- ◇ Highlight only the key words, and read only those.
- ◇ Never stop in the middle of a "but" or "however." That's clipping.
- ◇ Put the year in the cite, even when the card is older.
- ◇ Proofread for "Somali" vs. "Somalia."
